

tabs automatically on being re-opened.

One-click Bookmarking: You don't need to do a [Ctrl] + [D] to bookmark a page. Simply click on the star in the location tab. If it turns golden, you've got a new favourite page.

Drag-and drop: You can select and pull text or hyperlinks from anywhere on a Web page and drop them straight into the search bar.

Intuitive Locator Bar: Firefox provides you with instant suggestions that drop down from the Locator bar above – which also doubles as a search bar.

Privacy: Firefox allows you to clear private data after browsing, deleting cookies, history and download details whenever you close the browser window. Particularly useful in Internet cafés.

What's Awful

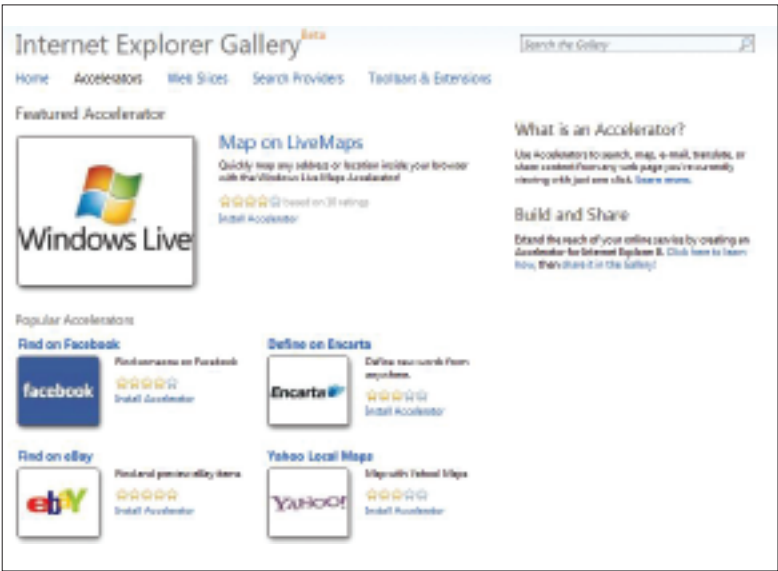
Too many add-ons: (is that really a problem?) It's quite possible that you may get a little overwhelmed with the sheer range of add-ons available for Mozilla. If you go overboard, this may clutter up the interface somewhat.

Slow Startup: While installing Firefox is a piece of cake, the initial startup time is a lemon. Click on the icon and it could take about 14 seconds to open the first time and four to eight seconds to start up later.

 **Internet Explorer 8**
With the impending competition, Microsoft launched the Internet Explorer 8 Beta 2 less than a week before Google Chrome. The Web site claims it is "Fast, Safe, Easy" and will "greatly enrich and improve your Web experience". IE8 already offers a lot of add-ons, some free, some not so free, and tabbed browsing (fully integrated since IE7). It's average startup time is better than all the other browsers around. There are a lot of parental controls that you can apply, providing greater protection to children from pernicious Web sites. Some of the really cool features are below.

What's Awesome

Accelerators: Internet Explorer 8 provides tools that easily allow access to multiple points of information such as translations, maps, definitions, etc. – all in a single window, to accelerate your access to information on the Web. You can choose from a whole list of services like About.com, Windows Live Search, CNet.com, Egisca Search, etc., to find the kind of information



you need directly from the tab on the top right of the screen, next to the Locator bar.

Web Slices: The 'Suggested Sites' button is definitely a brainwave that takes Internet Explorer one step ahead of Firefox. Microsoft uses 'Web Slices' technology to automatically trace sites that may be related to the one you are viewing, unlike the drop-down suggestions from the Locator bar (which are dependent on your viewing history). Using Web Slices, you can keep up with frequently updated sites directly from the Favorites Bar. If a Web Slice is available on a page, a green Web Slices icon will appear in the upper-right hand corner of the browser. You can then easily subscribe and add them to the Favorites Bar or delete Web Slices that are no longer desired. Updates then appear directly whenever information becomes available and the Web Slice appears highlighted. Click on the Web Slice for a preview and on the preview to get to the site itself.

Compatibility View: Old Web sites for old browsers sometimes don't open in new browsers with new features. IE8 has the Compatibility View option to allow you to open sites that new browser technology may not open optimally. You can find it in the 'Tools' button on the top right of the toolbar above.

Grouped Tabs: Another marvel in IE8 Beta 2 is the use of colours to group tabs. If you've got two dozen tabs open at the same time, it sometimes becomes difficult to remember which tab was a hyperlink in which other tab. Whenever you open a link on a page in a new tab the current tab and the new one both take on the same colour to show that they are part of a single group. As you click on new tabs they also appear in the same colours. You can

disable the colour feature if you find these too intrusive. The tabs can also be regrouped or ungrouped by dragging and dropping.

InPrivate Browsing: This is basically a feature that allows you to create a browsing session where cookies, history, passwords, form data and objects disappear once the browser is closed (akin to Firefox's 'Clear Private Data' provision).

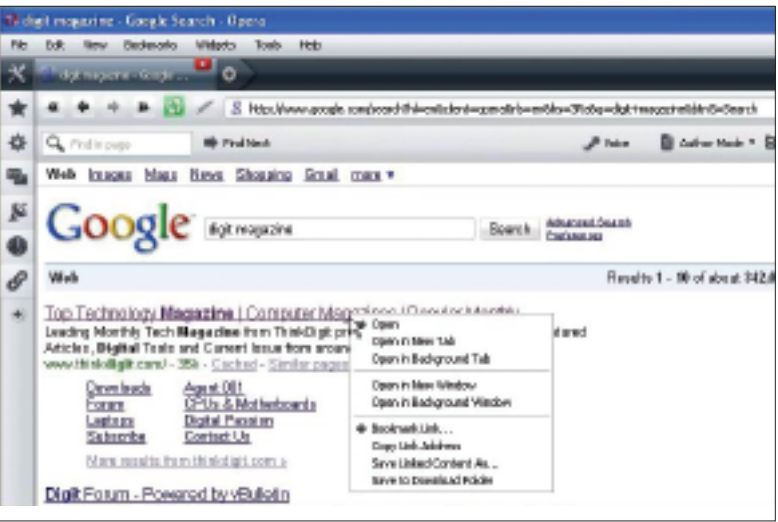
What's Awful

Looks: Try as it might, Microsoft just can't seem to match up with the cool, smooth and soft-hued graphics of Safari, the easy-on-the-eyes shades of Opera or the clear contrasts of Mozilla Firefox.

Still under copyright: If you don't already have a Internet Explorer, the MSN Web site will reject your request for download as invalid. In an age when there are browsers jostling to get into your computers for free – and even Chrome is open-source – it seems a little outdated to be restrictive with a browser that is anyway quite popular.

Opera 9.60 Beta

It is surprising that the usage of Opera is lower



than even Safari, when most critics and browser reviewers swear by it. It has a whole range of outstanding features such as quick find, thumbnail previews (which it calls 'Speed Dial'), skins and widgets. Tabbed browsing has an added feature (a unique one among browsers), allowing you to open a tab the way you like, either in the background or as a tab that takes over your screen.